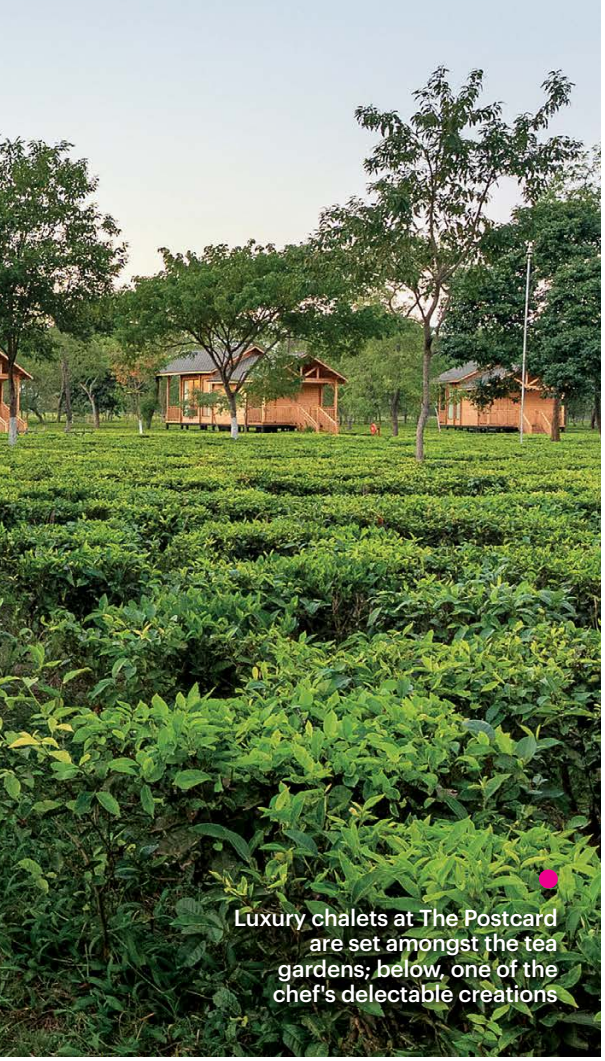


Luxury chalets at The Postcard are set amongst the tea gardens; below, one of the chef's delectable creations

an under-explored gem in India's luxury travel landscape, also primarily due to limited high-end hospitality options. However, with better connectivity and increasing awareness, we believe Assam is poised to become a key destination for discerning travellers."

One of India's most biodiverse states, Assam is home to seven national parks and 18 wildlife sanctuaries, including the iconic Kaziranga and Manas, both UNESCO-listed. Chopra believes that, as Assam experiences a surge in both domestic and international tourist arrivals, the luxury segment is set to evolve in a way that is experience-driven and rooted in authenticity. "Travellers today want meaningful connections with the destination. At The Postcard in the Durrung Tea Estate, we see this shift reflected in the growing demand for personalised, boutique experiences," he says.

Where the Living is Good

This is manifested in my stay in the Planter's Bungalow of The Postcard in the Durrung Tea Estate. The 150-year-old estate, started by a Scotsman in 1875, is still going strong, its 1,400 acres producing CTC black tea, as well as heading towards more premium orthodox production soon. The history and heft of the estate lend gravitas, while The Postcard Hotel tag brings the pizzazz. This property has been three years in the jazzing up, and the results are beyond what you'd imagine.

The shared areas in the main building have the elements of an Anglo-Indian bungalow: a long driveway leading to a porch, welcoming lobby easing into a dining area and a spacious upstairs that accommodates a sitting room and cosy lounge bar. But all these, as well as the wide wraparound verandahs, have been given a stylish makeover far from Raj-era fustiness. Floral, bird and butterfly motifs and photographs of rhinos dot the hotel's interiors, while elegant artwork from Chopra's own art gallery fits in seamlessly. In my suite, whites and pastels perfectly balance the fuchsias, greens and jewel-toned forest prints. All of this gives the décor a bright and breezy feel, even as it celebrates its colonial charm through dark wood furniture and a high four-poster bed.

Trailing the Tea

The unlimited welcome drinks at every Postcard property are much talked about in hospitality circles. At the Assam outpost, it's their signature tea-based cocktails that set the mood. The Hibiscus Blossom ushers you into plantation life, smoothly blending floral notes of hibiscus tea with herbaceous gin. Later, my creamy and intense Spiced Pineapple Old Fashioned made with Jim Beam bourbon and cardamom tea, seems just the right libation for a cool night under the full moon as I float on a surreal sea of tea bushes.

Maxing the Axom

The meals they plan place you in the location too. Pani pitha rice cakes at breakfast to Brahmaputra prawns, joha rice, elephant apple...the ingredients and recipes are as local as they come. The sleep-inducing Axomiya thali I try on my first afternoon is a burst of flavours. Be it bhetki fish from the river, a smokey eggplant mash, lai xaak khar (mustard greens in a banana-ash consommé) and pork (or chicken) in sesame gravy, or black rice kheer, it's a culinary journey into real Assamese flavours. During a cooking session with chef Phiba Nongrum, mustard oil releases its aroma, freshly picked tea leaves cosy up with batter to form pakodas, which in turn become the base for a chai patta chaat.

Actively Speaking

There are also so many other things to do and explore while on this tea-licious adventure. Do I safari in search of the one-horned rhino and famous golden tiger in Kaziranga (only two hours away); head to Dameri at dawn for a birdwatching trail, or serenely raft into the sunset on the Jia Bhoroli river there? The village walk through Sengeli Mari Gaon, a chance to watch the Eri and Muga silk weavers in action and hear their stories over a meal is great too.

This blend of the traditional and the trendsetting in their offerings is what the boutique chain aims for. And they've been successful in reinterpreting destinations for the discerning traveller by creating similarly plush and private places in surprising nooks. Speaking to other guests here, I realise just how much of a role a hotel brand that they're loyal to plays in bringing guests to experience a new destination. A few are here just because there's a new Postcard property, some primarily for the Kaziranga National Park and others for the stunning tea garden location. There's also much excitement about the new The Postcard on the Mighty Siang, coming up on the banks of the river in Pasighat in Arunachal Pradesh nearby.

Can't wait for the next postcard from the Northeast! ■